Before I could speak she blurted: *I shouldn't say this but I miss you!*

I shouldn't say this as well but I miss you too!

And then we just laughed and listened to each other breathe.

9.

I FELT ENORMOUS PRESSURE, the next day, sitting down to write the next letter. A paralyzing case of writer's block. I just couldn't find the words to express my excitement, my contentment, my longing. My hopes.

The next best thing, I figured, in the absence of lyricism, would be to make the letter physically beautiful.

Alas, I wasn't in a location conducive to arts and crafts. The lads' trip was now moving into phase three—an eight-hour game drive into the arse end of nowhere.

What to do?

At a break I jumped out of the truck, ran into the bush.

Spike, where you going?

I didn't answer.

What's with him?

Wandering wasn't advisable in these parts. We were deep in lion country. But I was hell-bent on finding…something.

I stumbled, staggered, saw nothing but endless brown grass. *Are we in the bloody Outback?*

Adi had taught me how to look for flowers in the desert. When it came to thornbushes, he always said, check the highest branches. So I did. And sure enough: Bingo! I climbed the thornbush, picked the flowers, put them into a little bag slung over my shoulder.

Later in our drive we came into a mopani forest, where I spotted two bright pink impala lilies.

I picked them too.

Soon enough I'd assembled a small bouquet.